Street Journal reporter who had flown to Pakistan on assignment, was kidnapped in Karachi and beheaded by terrorists with Al-Qaeda and Taliban training. General Musharraf and his army were unable to track down the killers fast enough, leaving the world aghast at how dangerous a country Pakistan had become, and how impossible it was to ensure the safety of even the most well-connected foreigners in cities as poor and crowded as Karachi. In his first address to Karachi's Legislative Assembly, Pakistan's Great Leader Jinnah had cautioned his countrymen that "the first duty of a Government is to maintain law and order,"[10] but after more than half a century, Pakistan appeared to have forgotten that wise advice.

How could so many billions in American dollars be poured into a country without requiring its recipients to invest even the smallest portion of it in measures of civil security and institution-building, sponsoring enough modern secular education to teach its police and its army at least how best to take effective action against criminals? Pearl's killers were eventually caught, several of them tried, one even sentenced to death, but that verdict remains under appeal. "How did we reach the present-day epidemic of terrorism and extremism?" Musharraf asks in his memoir, blaming the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan and its aftermath, which triggered the influx of so many Pathan refugees into Pakistan camps. Benazir Bhutto, however, blamed Musharraf himself and his military aides. Others blame Pakistan's feudal polity in Punjab and Sind, where great landowners still rule tens of thousands of serfs, who remain virtual slaves to their plows, while all along Pakistan's frontier armed Pathan and Balochi tribals remain restive, blaming their own government for failing to support them.

It is high time for Pakistan to move beyond the blame game into an era of comprehensive institutional change that starts with education and will ultimately lead to civil security and a political climate more conducive to economic development.